

Is Human Nature Good or Evil?  
The Answer According  
to Theology and Research Sources

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Is human nature good or evil? This is a question we must all ask, and it is the central topic of this paper. According to Christianity, the answer may seem simple: yes, human nature is good. However, is it really so? In this paper, I want to examine whether human nature is truly good or evil by looking at both Christian and non-Christian sources.

I believe that human nature contains some good elements. However, Christian theology teaches that even though there are good aspects of human nature, it is ultimately fallen and totally depraved. But is that the full picture? That is not the final word within Christianity, for it reflects primarily the perspective of John Calvin and the Calvinists. John Wesley, for instance, believed there are redeemable aspects of human nature. This brings us to the key question: can someone believe in Jesus Christ on the basis of this redeemable human nature?

From this, three main questions arise that this paper will address:

Is human nature good or evil?

Is human nature totally depraved?

Can humans believe in Jesus without the Holy Spirit?

According to Christianity, we are called to be good and loving, even when we are attacked. This very idea will guide our discussion in this article. Specifically, this paper is about counseling—Christian counseling—and the issue under consideration is defense mechanisms.

Most of us are familiar with defense mechanisms, but some may not know the term well. A defense mechanism is an instinctive response we use to protect ourselves in the face of danger. The central question here is whether this psychological and biological mechanism is actually moral and good. This naturally leads us to ask: is human nature, and the psychology of humanity itself, fundamentally good? If defense mechanisms are inherently evil, then human nature itself may also be evil.

According to this article, some people argue that defense mechanisms are a way to “avoid taking responsibility.”<sup>1</sup> Christians in particular may say that fighting back or reacting immediately is not an act of love. For example, when someone slaps you in the face, your immediate reaction may be to grab their arm and push them aside. But is this defense mechanism morally good? According to some Christians, it is sinful and wrong, since it avoids taking responsibility for the higher moral path—loving your neighbor as yourself and turning the other cheek.

This perspective contains some truth, but it is not the whole story. The reality is too complex to fully grasp with a simple answer. If you believe the solution is straightforward, you may be overlooking the deep moral and ethical complexity of the issue. Thus, from this discussion, it remains difficult to say whether human nature is ultimately good or evil.

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<sup>1</sup> - Fatimah Abdullah, “Human Behavior from an Islamic Perspective: Interaction of Nature, Nurture, and the Spiritual Dimension,” *The American Journal of Islam and Society* 28, no. 2 (December 31, 2011): 86–105.

Throughout this paper, in fact, it will be challenging to determine whether human nature is truly corrupt or whether it contains genuine traces of good.

John Calvin taught that human nature is totally depraved. But what if an act of defense—for example, pushing away the person who strikes you—actually saves another person's life? Would such an act not be good in the eyes of God and of Jesus Christ? Still, the question remains: is it salvific? The likely answer is no. Doing good by defending another person, though valuable, is still not sufficient to grant salvation. It is not a high enough good to earn entry into heaven.

and so we see that a person is able to do good in some sense but not able to do the highest good which is to earn salvation. however even this may be challenged because Wesleyan theology says that someone can actually attain the highest good and earned salvation through their own works. how a different article may be necessary in order to address this question because this article is addressing the question of defense mechanisms and of good and evil based on whether we treat our neighbor in a loving way in a way that is contradictory to normal behavior.

And so to conclude this article's analysis, we must say that it is inconclusive. defense mechanisms have a good sense and a bad sense. therefore human nature can be viewed as good or evil. and the reason why can be viewed as a good sense is because defense mechanisms can actually save a life in the end. but it can be viewed in a bad sense because Christianity says that even if you are to defend yourself, you are doing evil because you have to love your enemy. and loving your enemy means accepting whatever evil that comes your way. enter enter the question of whether an actual good or is there an actual evil and how do we know whether it's good or just

appears to be good or appears to be permissive of evil because if it's truly permissive of evil such as loving your neighbor in giving your other cheek, then isn't that promoting evil and causing evil isn't that essentially evil itself. and so we see that we're in a huge moral dilemma in analyzing this question. but the conclusion for this article is that we have examined it, and we are moving onto the next article and we cannot conclude a clear answer from the data. However, we have theology that tells us from the sky above of what the answer is.

“God always stands against mass calamities.”<sup>2</sup> this quote is from this next article, and his pointing at the fact that Covid is not necessarily caused by God. what's going on? Is this article is talking about whether calamities are a Christian topic - and the answer is a resounding yes. according to the authorities have been caused throughout history and in the Old Testament. and so we see this quote saying that God always stands against mass calamities does God actually always not want something bad happening in this world? and the answer is yes and no. once again, this is a question of morality of ethics end of the wisdom of God. it's going into the depths of the mysteries of God. and so we can stand against this quote and say it's not always that clear to say that God always always stands against mass calamities.

you see we have too many quotes in the Old Testament where God causes a calamity in order to destroy a people. but we have verses in the New Testament that says God is good and God is not the cause of any evil. and so the conclusion that we can make is that God uses evil, that God does not cause evil, but that God uses evil in order to achieve his purposes, such as destroying a certain race. and so to relate this back to the question of how does this relate to human nature is God does not kill people because they are good. God kills people

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<sup>2</sup> Joel S. Kaminsky, “‘A Plague Broke Out among Them’: Reflections on the Bible and the Pandemic,” *Interpretation* 77, no. 3 (December 31, 2023): 246–58.

because they are evil. and in fact, God kills every single person in the end. and thus we see that this flesh is not perfectly good. paul, the apostle says this flesh has some good things because when we're resurrected, we will be composed of similar materials. Will Paul the apostle also says that this flesh is sin and is of the sinful nature and he uses the word sarx (Greek) to denote something very bad. and so we understand that all of us are sinful at least to some degree. and the God's wrath is upon us. in the conclusion of this paragraph is that God causes calamities because of sin, but the direct cause is not easily found - therefore we cannot say that a certain person is experiencing a calamity because of a sin, but that sin in general has caused this calamity or that the specific sin is not able to be identified easily.

But we have seen in the Covid calamity and hurricane Katrina calamity that there has been good in the midst of calamity, and the reason for this is because there have been people and churches and organizations that have come to the aid of people who are needy and who need help. you see there's a big calamity, churches and good people come alongside these hurting people and help them. and when we see this happen, we see that there is a good and a good nature and human beings. and we find out the people who help the most are Christians and so we see that Christ may very well create a good human nature.

“This recalls Aristotle’s view that the virtuous person and real philosopher should not seek refuge in words or theories (logoi), but put every effort into virtuous practical activity.”<sup>3</sup> what this quote is saying is that people should not think about virtue and expel about virtue and write papers about human nature but rather actually be a good person. and so we see this conflict in humanity where the Jews are studying the law and trying to find out how to be a good person

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<sup>3</sup> Angel Suet Man Lam, “Defences, Human Nature, and Spiritual Awakening: A Christian Counselling Perspective,” *Religions* 15, no. 5 (December 31, 2024): 1–14.

and they are examining the moral and ethical issues and they're saying we need to break some rules in order to be good and we need to do these things in order to follow the law and we see that the law of God is perfect and good and that we cannot fully follow it and we see that no matter how many papers that we write about ethics that we will never become perfect or even maybe even get better. the truth is that it is the spirit that truly gives life and that the letter or the flesh cannot give life at all. therefore we shall not think about how we should be better, but we should yield our spirits to the Holy Spirit. and how can people yield their spirits to the Holy Spirit if they have not hurt the gospel preached - this is therefore a command from God to preach the gospel and to make his spirit known to people. we cannot just do regular activity being a teacher of English in order to spread the gospel. We need to actually get the spirit of God to actively work in the lives of people. now there is a role for being an English teacher, but there is also a role to administer the holy Bible and the Holy Spirit to people. and once again the question of ethics of whether human nature is good or evil is may not be the center question because we may not be able to answer that question but the solution to whether it's good or evil is to say that we need the Holy Spirit that we need God that we need Jesus Christ.

“Questioned about the highest goal of life, Galen refuses the Epicurean ideals of pleasure (hêdonê) and freedom from disturbance (aochlêsia),<sup>25</sup> and instead favours Aristotle’s account of happiness, which he understands as “the activity in accordance with virtue.” and so what Aristotle or Plato was saying in this quote here is he is saying that happiness is the best way to live and happiness. He defines as the activity in “accordance with virtue.” and so we see that

Greek philosophy has a degree of truth and has a degree of congruence with Christianity and with the true truth. and so we see an all cultures in Greek philosophy, and an Asian philosophy that there is a leaning towards Yahweh. and somebody say human nature is good. they may say it is not perfect, but it is good. and they may say it may have some evil or it may have no evil or it may get evil from a different place, but all of these questions are too complex to solve in this paper. What we can say is there is common grace in the world. and thus there is a receptivity towards the true gospel in all people and cultures. and that very much preach the gospel in order to make the world a better place and to make human nature a little bit better.

“Human nature (fitrah) is still vibrant and dynamic.”<sup>4</sup> this is a quote from Islam. what did they saying is that human nature is good and evil and it has a lot of complexities to it and we can't really pinpoint if it's good or evil you know in a black-and-white way. so we're learning from this is that human nature is so complex and so vibrant and dynamic according to this quote that we're not able to pinpoint an exact answer and this is exactly the conclusion that I want to make in this paper that we cannot pinpoint the exact answer of whether human nature is good or evil or how good or how evil or how it becomes good or how it becomes evil. It's hard to answer all of these question. but I want to correct myself in saying that there is a question answer to how human nature can become good and that is through the proclamation of Jesus Christ and through the sacraments. and Islam will say that human nature we cannot define possibly whether it's good or evil, but we need to do the religion of Islam in order to make the world a better place and to do the will of Allah. and time will tell if this religion of Islam is coming from a true place of goodness in the human heart and the human nature or whether this religion

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<sup>4</sup> Julia Trompeter, *Galen on Ethics and Human Nature*, vol. 174 (Leiden: Brill, 2025).

of Islam is coming from the flesh and not from God. and that's Christians. We will say that Islam has some degrees of truth that it comes from Judeo-Christian background, but ultimately it is not the Christian God. and so we will conclude that human nature is evil because it distort the Bible and distort the truth.

“Homouousios” and “hypostasis.”<sup>5</sup> these two words are theological words written by Gregory, I believe and so we understand that there is a debate of what these words mean. I believe that Gregory was saying that hypothesis is not a correct word and that there is a debate on whether the holy Trinity is unified in the sense that they are very close together, or they are unified in the sense that they are actually the same substance, and this debate on the word hypothesis shows that the nature of God is hotly debated. and is this not somewhat of an insult to God and saying that you know I think he looks good in a white hat and a black cat when he actually enjoys being in a certain hat. and so we're saying that we're making a certain picture of God and it's not actually the picture that God is. and according to John Calvin, our understanding of God directly relates to our understanding of ourselves. if we view God as a someone who we cannot completely understand, how can we view ourselves and understand ourselves because looking at yourself is harder than looking at some object that you can see clearly in some sense. and so this debate about hypostasis shows us that the nature of a person is hotly debated, and that we cannot completely know the truth about the nature of a person.

and just as an aside, I want to focus on whether we can know the nature of a person someone may do something that looks apparently evil, but may be actually good and someone may do something that looks good but it's actually evil and so we see that appearances do not tell

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<sup>5</sup> Johannes Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of Nyssa: Philosophical Background and Theological Significance*, vol. 46 (Leiden: Brill, 2000).

all the answers, and that the nature is something that goes to the core of something and that we cannot know exactly what's at the core of everything because it's too hidden. and so asking the question of human nature is human nature is composed of many layers there's an outer layer that is could be flipping good flipping evil but human nature is essentially a question of what's at the core of mankind. and if we look at the universe, we see that we can look at the core of the universe and say there is an atom you know things are atomized. There is an individual particular matter thing there and it has a certain charge it is plus or minus it has a certain chemical substance and so if we are to view our human nature or something as material in a sense, then we can say you know is it you know a particular charge? Is it a particular you know a spin. and just as it is hard to truly know what an atom is like it is hard to know what the human nature is like.

but that's not Jesus say a good tree bears good fruit, and the way that we do experiments in science is we have to do reactions and kind of relations in order to find out the nature of something and so we can do an experiment on a grand scale of humanity on the world scale and say is God good is humans. and so we have a question of is the nature of Jesus Christ good you know and this is a big can of worms because Jesus Christ's God so how can he be bad but we understand that he carried around with possibly the sinful flesh that was part of Mary. and so we see that the question of the human nature is not an easy question because if Jesus Christ nature was completely good, he would not completely understand sin and it's affects on him. It would just be an outer kind of suffering. It would not be us inner suffering of difficulty in his inner core because he is good and he is already omnipotent, able to overcome all evil, but if he was bad, then he wouldn't be gone, and so we understand that his human nature was good, but that he

carried around with him and outer kind of suffering of the flesh that trained him in order to become a super God man.

go back to the question of humankind you know what is humankind evil or good at its core and once again the answer to this is we can do an experiment to see you know what does mankind produce and we see that it is good and evil but the ultimate end the ultimate end tells you the truth is it not the true fruit of the person comes out after years and years and we see that the true fruit of man is utter destruction that we destroy ourselves with nuclear weapons or through our own sin, and so we understand that we are sinful, and that we are truly evil we are evil. We are not good. That is the conclusion of this paper. we understand that on the surface we may be good but the true core of our being is evil because that is one is the fruit of our laborers after 1 billion years. but we see that we have a Holy Spirit residing in us we see that we are making progress and that there is good in the world and so we see that the Holy Spirit is making good appear in this world and making human nature, which was bad good in when the Holy Spirit fills us.

in conclusion, human nature is defined as evil because overtime human race will destroy itself, and it's not exactly a good thing that ends at the end. and because the quality of something, and the actual essence of something is discovered after years and years and years, we see that the human race is truly evil at its core. but what is the solution to this problem and how should we live our lives? we see that we need to believe in Jesus Christ and have the Holy Spirit regenerate our hearts, and to make our being good by being filled with the Holy Spirit. the question of ethics is not some theory as Aristotle stated in this paper, we will understand that the question of ethics is how to make the real thing good and the answer to that is the Holy Spirit.

The Greeks were wisdom and Jews were miracles but we preach Christ crucified, which is a stumbling block to Greek and Jews. and so we see that the Greeks had some idea of the truth, but they were missing the true answer. They were looking in the dark and they knew that the answer is some light something that looks like a lie something that looks bright and maybe has three parts to it that is one, but they lack the complete understanding of what that is and the revelation that allows them to see it. and so we see that human nature lies and darkness, and that we need special revelation in order to view the truth. Wesley in theory may be correct and that people can understand God through general revelation however, the question is how many people will be able to be saved through that means. and we see that that is a difficult question because not many people believe in Holy Spirit through General revelation.

So the conclusion of this paper human nature is evil and we need the Holy Spirit to fill us in order to make the world a better place.

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